

International AS and A-level

Psychology (9685)

PS03 Advanced Topics and Research Methods 2

Report on the examination

June 2024

REPORT ON EXAMINATION: INTERNATIONAL A-LEVEL PSYCHOLOGY (9685) PS03 JUNE 2024

Performance on this exam was comparable to previous series. However, there was again a distinct difference in students' performances across the three sections on the paper, with many doing well on Section A and Section B, with Section B often scoring the highest marks overall. However, there was a lower level of attainment shown for Section C. Within Section C there was often a noticeable lack of students' research methods knowledge and understanding, even on questions that assessed the content from their AS studies. Whilst I am confident that teachers have covered the research methods content successfully, it is an area that needs more revision and practice during the lead up to the examinations.

QUESTION 01

Most students were able to gain at least half of the marks available for this question. However, the main issue related to a lack of clear links between knowledge about the effects of shift work and the information provided in the scenario. Some students also lost focus on the question, providing lengthy descriptions of the role of the SCN as an endogenous pacemaker and how Kazem's SCN is being influenced by the exogenous zeitgeber of light. Answers of this nature rarely gained credit as they were not focused on the demands of the question, which was about the effects of shift work.

QUESTION 02.1 & 02.2

Most were able to answer both questions well, with performance on question 02.2 being slightly stronger. There was a good use of psychological terminology in many responses to this question. However, there was some confusion shown in the examples provided by students, particularly for question 02.1. Some inaccurate examples of endogenous pacemakers included reference to the sleep-wake cycle itself, as well as specifying the pineal gland and melatonin. The pineal gland and melatonin are not endogenous pacemakers as they are ultimately influenced by the activity of the SCN and were therefore not creditworthy.

QUESTION 03

Most students were able to provide a decent response that achieved at least half of the available marks. Some answers demonstrated a very good understanding of memory consolidation as a function of sleep. The best responses referred to the role of nREM and REM in consolidating different types of memories and some information about the neurological processes involved.

The main issue that arose for this question was a lack of clarity. Some answers were unable to move beyond simply reusing the wording of the theory. For example, stating that memory consolidation is when we consolidate our memories. Responses of this nature did not receive any credit. It is important that students remember to go beyond the information that has already been provided, such as clarifying what consolidation means rather than just re-using the term.

QUESTION 04

This question was a good discriminator as there was a significant variation in marks. Some were able to produce an excellent response. This included a clear and effective strength and limitation of the **oxfordaqa.com**

evolutionary explanations of sleep. However, whilst many students were able to identify relevant evaluations, these often lacked the clarity and additional detail required to move them into a level 3 response.

Additionally, some candidates provided very lengthy and unnecessary descriptions of the evolutionary explanations themselves, rather than focusing on the evaluation. It is important that students read the questions carefully, identifying the command words so they can structure their responses appropriately.

QUESTION 05

Some students were able to provide an excellent answer that met the level 4 marking criteria. However, many responses demonstrated very little understanding of what constituted a personality factor, often referring to issues with family trauma, depression, shift work and jet lag. Some of these points could have been made relevant if they had been used correctly and effectively. A number of responses highlighted issues with chronotype and explained the principle of people being 'owls' or 'larks.' Few however went on to clarify how this related to insomnia.

Another issue was that many evaluations focused on methodological issues of research studies into insomnia. Whilst this could be creditworthy, these responses often received little credit as they did not highlight how the methodological issues could become strengths or limitations of the role of personality factors or genetics in insomnia.

Finally, there was some misunderstanding of the requirements for the command word of 'discuss.' Whilst students often picked up marks for their description of the role of personality factors and genetics in insomnia, they neglected to include any discussion points, therefore, missing out on the AO3 element of the question. Students must be familiar with the various command words that could appear in examination questions and what is required within their answers.

QUESTION 06

Students did not perform well on this question. Under half were able to achieve the full 2 marks available. There were two main recurring issues. Firstly, some students could not provide a clear explanation of the term 'dysfunctional thought processing.' This term does appear on the specification and therefore students are expected to be able to define what it means. Some simply re-wrote the term in a different order, such as stating that is when a person processes their thoughts in a dysfunctional way. These responses did not gain any credit.

The other issue was that some did not give an actual example of a dysfunctional thought. Instead, they provided a vague issue like stating language deficit problems. The best responses kept their example simple, suggesting issues such as, 'delusions beliefs that people are trying to hurt you.'

QUESTION 07.1 & 07.2

Most were able to answer question 07.1 well, gaining both marks available. However, there was sometimes inaccurate terminology given for some of the symptoms. Additionally, some responses named symptoms of schizophrenia but did not explicitly link these to the scenario about Asha.

Students found question 07.2 more challenging than 07.1. Many overcomplicated their answers, providing unnecessary percentage statistics of inheritance chances which were not relevant or directly related to the scenario of Asha, her father and grandmother. Other responses lost focus on the question and started referring to environmental factors, particularly diathesis-stress

explanations. There were no environmental factors identified in the scenario and therefore, this was not relevant for this question.

QUESTION 08

Many were able to produce a decent response to this question, providing some relevant evaluation points for the genetic theory. It was pleasing to see that most responses were focused on providing evaluations, rather than unnecessary descriptions of the genetic theory, which has been the case in the past on similar types of questions.

Some of the most common responses focused on the issue of the genetic explanation being reductionist. However, some answers confused reductionism with determinism. Additionally, some students provided very vague and generic answers eg stating that there is supporting research evidence but failed to provide any further clarification or detail. Responses of this nature often receive very little credit. Students must continue to practice their evaluation skills and avoid making generic and vague statements. Actual examples of supporting or criticising research must be provided if that is the focus of the evaluation.

QUESTION 09

Many were able to produce a good essay, with around half of all students managing to write a response worthy of the level 3 criteria. There were some outstanding essays that demonstrated an in-depth understanding and evaluation of the use of anti-psychotic drugs as a therapy for schizophrenia.

The main recurring issue is that some focused their answer too much on trying to name many different types of anti-psychotic drugs and listing their associated side effects. Whilst this did gain some credit, it often did not address the important issue, which is how these drugs actually work at treating schizophrenia, such as reference to blocking the dopamine (D2) receptors. While it is very impressive that some students can remember the names and side effects of so many different types of drugs, they must remember to include the key information about how these drugs work once they have been taken.

QUESTION 10

Most students performed well on this question, clearly and accurately identifying the aim of the study. However, some students became confused and thought this study was a correlation. The scenario did not concern investigating a relationship, and therefore no credit was given for reference to a correlation. Students must be able to identify the difference between an experiment and a correlation.

QUESTION 11

This question should have been a very straight-forward one. However, it was very poorly answered. Less than half were able to correctly identify that the study was a natural experiment, although credit was given for answers that stated a field experiment. Many students did not seem to understand what the question was asking, instead providing responses relating to sampling methods, or experimental designs. Alternatively, some became too focused on how the DV was being measured, via a question asking the participants to rate level of excitement. Consequently, these students incorrectly stated that the study was a questionnaire or interview.

QUESTION 12

There was a lot of confusion over this question. Many were able to state that a non-directional hypothesis should be used. However, less than half could correctly explain why this was the case.. Students need to understand the reasoning behind when and why a psychologist/researcher would use a directional or non-directional hypothesis for their study.

QUESTION 13

Whilst most students were able to achieve 2 out of the 3 marks available, fewer were able to write a clear and appropriate hypothesis, worthy of the full 3 marks. Students do seem to have become more skilled at writing hypotheses in comparison to previous examinations. To achieve the full 3 marks, students needed to write a non-directional hypothesis where both the IV and DV were clear and fully operationalised. Some only operationalised either the IV or DV and therefore gained a maximum of 2 marks.

A few students wrote a fully operationalised directional hypothesis. However, since the study required the use a non-directional hypothesis, they were limited to a maximum of 2 marks overall.

Some students wrote the aim of the study or vague statements that could not be considered hypothesis.

Finally, as with question 10, some became confused about the nature of the study, and wrote a correlational hypothesis. As this study was not a correlation, these responses could not receive any credit.

QUESTION 14

Many students struggled with this question, particularly in relation to the range. Most were able to identify (from the mean) that group 2 were more excited than group 1 but failed to justify their statement using the data. However, many students struggled to interpret what the range values told them about the results. Students need to be able to explain what the range means and how to interpret it, rather than just how to calculate it. The mark scheme for this question can provide a lot of guidance for this area.

QUESTION 15

Despite many answering this question correctly, I was concerned about the number of students who, in their second year of studying psychology, did not know what the term experimental design referred to. Incorrect responses ranged from listing experimental and non-experimental methods, through to naming sampling methods and even statistical tests. A common issue that held some students back was that whilst they obtained the first mark for identifying the experimental design, they did not clearly explain how this study was an example of an independent groups design. Instead, they provided a generic definition of an independent groups design, which could not receive the additional mark.

QUESTION 16

This question was a good discriminator. Whilst most students were able to demonstrate some understanding of the purpose of statistical tests, only a few were able to provide responses that gained either 2 or the full 3 marks. Students need to focus on understanding why statistical testing is used in psychology. The mark scheme for this question provides some useful guidance here..

QUESTION 17

This is the first time a 7-mark question dedicated to statistical tests has been asked. Only a few students were able to achieve the full 7 marks, however many were able to obtain at least 3 or 4 marks. Within their answers, students were not disadvantaged if they incorrectly identified the statistical test. Whilst they did not receive any credit for the incorrect test, they were able to still gain credit for identifying the appropriate elements of the study, such as treatment as ordinal data, independent groups, and test of a difference. The main issue that prevented many from gaining higher marks was the lack of application back to the scenario. For example, many students stated that the data type used was ordinal which gained them 1 mark, but they did not apply their knowledge of the level of measurement to the design of the study.

QUESTION 18

It was pleasing to see that most students got this question correct, demonstrating accurate knowledge of the sections of a scientific report.

QUESTION 19

This should have been a relatively straightforward question. However, less than half of all students were able to achieve both marks available. Many did not seem to fully understand what was meant by co-variables. Some responses referred to extraneous variables, whilst others only listed one of two different co-variables, usually the number of sporting events, but failed to identify the other co-variable being the excitement rating (on a scale of 1-10).

A common issue was that many students referred to an IV and DV but correctly identified the two co-variables, one as the IV and the other as the DV. In these situations, reference to IV and DV was ignored, so that full credit could be awarded. However, it is important for students to understand that an IV and DV relate to experiments, whilst co-variables apply to correlational studies.

QUESTION 20

This question was poorly answered overall with very few managing to obtain the full 4 marks. This either reflected a lack of revision in this area, or that it was the final question on the examination and students were possibly running out of time.

A limitation of correlations tended to be the best answer, in comparison to the strength. Most referred to the issue of not being able to establish cause and effect. However, they did not provide any further details. This often held their responses back to level 1 marking criteria.

Some students became confused when trying to explain a strength of correlations. Simply writing what a correlation is as their strength such as stating that correlations are good because they investigate the relationship between two variables, or that they show a correlation. These responses did not receive credit as this is not an appropriate strength.